

Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP)

snapcoalition.org/
Policy Hackathon 2026

Policy <> Track J

Energy & AI Data Center Infrastructure

About This Track:

This challenge is part of the Policy Hackathon 2026 J track: Energy / AI Data Centers. Design a policy response to AI compute demand straining electric grids and ratepayer costs.

Use Case Description:

AI compute demand is straining electric grids, driving up ratepayer costs, and forcing states to decide how to permit, power, and pay for data centers. This challenge asks teams to design a policy response for a specific grid region or state.

Problem Statement:

Deciding how to permit, power, and pay for the AI data-center boom.

- Select a focus: data-center rate design, interconnection-queue reform, behind-the-meter/on-site generation permitting, water use for cooling, or transparency/siting disclosure requirements.
- Ground the problem in grid and load-growth data for the chosen region.
- Review existing regulatory tools (state PUC rate cases, FERC interconnection rules, local zoning/siting authority).
- Design a policy proposal balancing ratepayer protection, grid reliability, and continued investment.
- Assess tradeoffs: economic development benefits vs. reliability risk vs. cost-shifting to residential ratepayers.

Possible Approaches:

- Rate-design — a special data-center rate class with minimum-take contracts to protect other ratepayers.
- Interconnection-reform — redesign the queue/process for large-load or generation interconnection.
- Siting/permitting — a state or local siting framework with community-benefit and disclosure requirements.
- Reliability — demand-response, curtailment, or on-site generation rules for data centers as flexible load.

Challenge Duration:

- Teams start working in September 2026
- Submission on **November 14, 2026**. There will be no extension to the submission deadline.

Team Guidelines:

- Team size — **3–5 participants per team, interdisciplinary encouraged.**
- Ensure you are enrolled as a participant in Policy Hackathon 2026.
- Everyone is eligible to participate in this challenge and win awards.
- Standout teams may be invited to brief partner organizations or judges directly on their proposal.

Challenge Tasks / Deliverables:

- 4–6 page policy brief with load-growth/grid data and recommendation
- One-page fact sheet for a state PUC or legislature audience
- Slide deck (8–10 slides)
- A simple cost-allocation table showing who pays under current rules vs. the reform
- Process appendix (0.5 page)

Optional Advanced Tasks:

- Build a simple load-growth projection chart for the chosen region
- Interview a utility, PUC staffer, or community advocate (with consent)
- Comparative case study of another state's data-center rate case or siting rule
- A ratepayer-impact one-pager in plain language

Platforms and Tools:

- Data: EIA, FERC filings, state PUC dockets, grid operator (RTO/ISO) load forecasts
- Legislative tracking: state legislature sites, FERC eLibrary, Regulations.gov
- Drafting/collaboration: Google Docs, shared repo

Judging Criteria:

- Technical grid/energy accuracy — **25%**
- Ratepayer-protection analysis — **20%**
- Feasibility (regulatory + political) — **20%**
- Balance of reliability, cost, and growth tradeoffs — **20%**
- Presentation quality — **15%**

Data Privacy / Eligibility Restriction:

- Use only public utility filings, PUC dockets, and EIA/FERC data — no proprietary data without permission.
- Do not include specific critical-infrastructure security vulnerabilities — keep analysis at the policy/rate-design level.
- Disclose AI tool use.

Participants retain ownership of their submissions but grant Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP) the right to evaluate, discuss, and showcase submitted work for educational and research purposes, with appropriate attribution.